



Rating: 7/10
 Developer: Electronic Arts
 Publisher: Electronic Arts
 Distributor: Milestone Interactive
 Contact:
sales@milestoneinteractive.com
 Minimum System Requirements:
 CPU running at 1.7GHz or higher,
 64MB DirectX 9.0c
 compatible video card,
 512 MB RAM



show off the lighting effects the game is capable of. For the looks, *NFS* is unnecessarily resource-hungry. Cars look slightly better than those in *Most Wanted*, the road looks far worse; there was no justification for the fact that the only card that can run it at 1600 x 1200 and everything turned on, without framing, is the 8800GTX. Criminal.

Another new feature is the overhyped Autosculpt, which takes the number of ways you can customise your car to obscene highs. Quite nice if you're into that sort of thing, but ultimately, it's just eyewash.

Brass Tacks

To win territories in the game, you have to race against the bosses in a three-tiered event. The first is a basic *Most Wanted*-style race on a city track followed by the Canyon Duel—the most refreshing part of the game. This is a two-stage affair where you first follow your opponent along a winding canyon track, gaining points as you inch ever closer. In the next round, the positions are reversed and you lose more points if your opponent comes close. If your points come down to zero, you lose. And yes, this is the first *NFS* since *NFS 2* where you can fall off a cliff (or canyon track in this case) and lose the game.

Drift races make a comeback again—another lemon of a decision. While handling does change dramatically, these cars are *not* built for drifting well—realistic games like *Project Gotham Racing* or the insanely arcade-ish *Ridge Racer* are much better suited for such activities.

The rest of the game is pretty straightforward, and if you've played *Most Wanted* recently, irritatingly repetitive—including the cop chases. There are some little things that are quite neat—traffic now responds to oncoming racers with nervousness, and it may even be possible that cabbies are the worst of the lot. Even in the Canyon Duels, your opponent starts making mistakes if you stick to his/her bumper for too long.

Bottom Line

If you're just off the *Most Wanted* high, wait a few months before you go near this one—*Most Wanted* is a far superior game, and won't tax your graphics card as much. If you've never played an *NFS* title, *Carbon* is going to prove quite enjoyable.

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